Chapter 12 – The Taj Mahal and a Story of Love

Babur's kingdom passed to his grandson Humayun, who at his death bestowed it upon his own son Jahangir. When Jahangir breathed his last, his four sons fought over the succession until Shah Jahan, born in January of 1592, murdered his brother, cousins, and all male rivals for his father's throne. He became the emperor in 1628, at the age of 36. It was an incongruous beginning to the rule of the Mughal Emperor who would actually be remembered for his tender love story. Today, Shah Jahan's monument of love, the Taj Mahal, is visited by 60,000 people every day.

Shah Jahan's love story began long before he gained power; it happened at the age of 15 in the marketplace of Agra. There, he saw a beautiful girl whose presence filled him with desire and adoration. The two fell in love instantly, and a marriage was planned. Though they were forced to wait five years for the wedding to take place, their feelings did not waver, nor did they question the powerful emotions that had overtaken them upon meeting.

In true Mughal style, Shah Jahan was both bloodthirsty in battle and quite intellectual in politics. He adored architecture and set about building beautiful palaces throughout his kingdom that were crafted of brilliant white marble. They would come to further define the urban landscape of India, Pakistan, Afghanistan, and many south Asian and Middle Eastern countries, as well as the Muslim faith itself. Jahan knew that it was both his right and in his faith's tradition that he marry more than one woman. While he waited for the far-off date his astrologers proposed for the wedding to Mumtaz Mahal, Jahan chose another bride to marry right away. At the age of 20, Shah Jahan married his first choice and eventually became husband to three women. Upon the final marital union in 1612, the newlyweds embarked upon their life together with gusto.

Mumtaz Mahal was not just a lovely trinket for her husband to admire. Though Shah Jahan showered her with gifts, he also treasured their friendship and her wisdom. The couple sought counsel from one another as well as tenderness. On March 23rd, 1614, the empress gave birth to their first child, a daughter named Jahanara Begum. The next year, they welcomed a prince to the family and called him Dara Shikoh. These were just the first of 14 children the royal couple would have together, though, as was normal for this time in history, only seven of the babies would survive to become adults. Still, the family was large and promising.